



Bites and Envenomation

Assessment

Pediatric Pearls:

- Use pediatric dosing of medications or electrical therapy for a pediatric patient < 37 kg and as defined by the PEDIA Tape.

Signs & Symptoms:

- Rash, skin break, wound pain, soft tissue swelling, redness
- Blood oozing from the bite wound
- Evidence of infection
- Shortness of breath, wheezing
- Allergic reaction, hives, itching
- Hypotension or shock

Differential:

- Animal bite
- Human bite
- Snake bite (poisonous)
- Spider bite (poisonous)
- Insect sting / bite (bee, wasp, ant, tick)
- Infection risk
- Rabies risk
- Tetanus risk

Clinical Management Options

P	P	P	P	P	P
L	L	L	L	L	L
1	2	3	4	5	6

- If Insect Bite:
 - Remove stinger, if appropriate
 - Apply ice pack
 - Minimize movement and remove constricting items
- If Snake Bite
 - [Splint limb](#), bandage
 - If pit viper – elevate affected limb 60 degrees
 - If coral snake – maintain at level of the heart
 - Minimize movement and remove constricting items
- [Pain Management Guideline](#) as needed

Consult Online Medical Control As Needed

Pearls:

- Refer to drug formulary charts for all medication dosing for both adults and pediatric patients.
- Human bites have a very high risk of infection due to oral bacteria.
- Carnivore bites are much more likely to become infected and all have risk of Rabies exposure.
- Cat bites may rapidly progress to infection due to a specific bacteria (*Pasteurella multocida*).
- Venomous snakes in this area are generally of the pit viper family: rattlesnake, copperhead, and water moccasin – Less than 10-15% of pit viper bites are “dry bites,” envenomation can present as swelling, bruising, duskiness, or skin stretching. May not always seen fang marks.
 - Coral snake bites are rare: Very little pain but very toxic.
 - It is **NOT** necessary to take the snake to the ED with the patient. Take Picture if possible.
- Black Widow spider bites have minimal pain initially but may develop muscular pain and severe abdominal pain (spider is black with red hourglass on belly). Bite often develops local diaphoresis.
- Brown Recluse spider bites are minimally painful to painless. Little reaction is noted initially but tissue necrosis at the site of the bite develops over the next few days (brown spider with fiddle shape on back). OK to use ice pack for this bite. Most are uncomplicated.
- Evidence of infection: swelling, redness, drainage, fever, red streaks proximal to wound.
- Immunocompromised patients are at an increased risk for infection.(diabetes, chemotherapy, transplant patients)
- May use soap and water to clean wounds if time and patient condition allows.
- Consider contacting the US/Texas Poison Control Center for guidance. 1-800-222-1222
- Bats, skunks, foxes, and raccoons are the most common rabies vectors. Dogs have been eliminated as reservoirs of rabies unless; known contact with a high-risk animal.